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Robert Rivas takes charge as California Assembly speaker

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It's a day that seemed like it might not ever happen: Robert Rivas will be sworn in Friday morning as the next speaker of the California Assembly.

The ascension of the Salinas Democrat to lead the lower chamber of the Legislature brings to a definitive close (for now) a dramatic power struggle that bitterly divided the majority caucus of the Assembly last summer and fall.

Internal changes that shake up how the state Capitol operates, such as rewarding close allies with powerful leadership roles and committee posts, are likely coming in the months ahead. What Rivas' tenure will mean for the average Californian is less certain.

Rivas has a similar ideological profile to his longtime predecessor — the outgoing Speaker Anthony Rendon, a progressive Democrat from Lakewood — so supporters do not expect a dramatic shift in the priorities of Assembly Democrats.

But they note his promise, as he cobbled together votes last year from a diverse coalition of members, to establish an inclusive decision-making process, which supporters hope will lead to a more coherent and intentional legislative agenda.

"I'm expecting to see progress bringing the caucus together to address the most long-standing and significant policy issues facing California," such as housing and climate change, said Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, a Woodland Hills Democrat.

Rivas could also potentially ring in an era of closer collaboration with Gov. Gavin Newsom, who has clashed at times with lawmakers as he has increasingly sought to pursue his ambitious agenda through the Legislature.

At an event Thursday, Newsom expressed excitement about working with Rivas, whom he noted was an early endorser of his as Newsom launched his campaign for governor before winning his first term in 2018.

"I have a bias for him. He was there for me early, when I first ran for governor, when others didn't want to jump in the primary," Newsom said. "I'm a big fan of the incoming speaker. So I feel blessed, because it's not always the case."

A long transfer of power

Rivas first made his move on the speakership more than a year ago, prompting a messy six-hour standoff in a closed-door caucus meeting that concluded with Rendon still in charge.

That might have marked the end for Rivas' aspirations, but he continued to aggressively cultivate support in the lead-up to the November election, particularly among new candidates running for their first term in the Assembly. He set up his own fundraising operation to support their campaigns, which effectively served as a rival to the California Democratic Party's efforts, irking Rendon and his allies.

Rivas was also boosted by Govern For California, a donor network pushing the boundaries of state campaign

finance law, whose political advisers include his brother.

After another six-hour meeting with the newly-elected Assembly Democratic caucus in November, Rivas emerged with an agreement to finally take over as speaker on June 30 — though even that didn't entirely calm potential challengers during the lengthy transition period.

Raised in farmworker housing on the rural Central Coast by his single mother and grandparents, Rivas will add a fresh outlook to a role that is traditionally held by members from the urban corridors of power in Los Angeles or the Bay Area, according to his supporters. They frequently point to his rise as an illustration of the California dream.

"Each of us brings to the floor different lived experiences and perspectives," said Assemblymember Rebecca Bauer-Kahan, an Orinda Democrat.

That could benefit agricultural communities and other groups who are not generally the central focus of policy-making in Sacramento.

Assemblymember Buffy Wicks, an Oakland Democrat, said that because of his upbringing, Rivas is sensitive to the needs of people who don't have a lobbyist advocating for them at the Capitol and he will fight for them.

"He's an incredibly kind, thoughtful leader," Wicks said. "And in politics, that's not always a given, is it?"

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